

Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines for Livestock at Processing Establishments

The AWTG is developing new Australian Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines for Livestock at Processing Establishments (the processing standards). The processing standards will replace the 2002 [Model Code of Practice for the Welfare of Animals: Livestock at Slaughtering Establishments](#).

While this large and complex project has taken longer than anticipated, the AWTG remain committed to delivering this important work.

The processing standards are being informed by a 2021 independent scientific literature review:

A Stakeholder Advisory Group (SAG) comprising key national stakeholder organisations was consulted in 2022, 2023 and 2024.

Read the SAG terms of reference and membership list:

Public consultation on the draft processing standards is scheduled for 2025-26. Following consultation, a national Regulation Impact Analysis (RIA) will quantify and assess the likely impacts of the proposed standards and guidelines. Once finalised, the processing standards and RIA will be reviewed by the AWTG and the Agriculture Senior Officials' Committee before being presented to agriculture ministers for final endorsement.

Project timeline

Current progress

A sub-group of the AWTG is working to address jurisdictional feedback on a third draft of the processing standards in preparation for public consultation in 2025-26.

Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines - Land Transport of Livestock – suitability for horses

Queensland, on behalf of AWTG completed a review of the Australian Animal Welfare Standards and Guidelines – Land Transport of Livestock (the land transport standards) for their suitability for horses.

- 2021-2022

A Consultation Regulatory Impact Statement (CRIS) was published by the Office of Impact Analysis (OIA) on 21 September 2022. [View the CRIS](#). The proposals in the CRIS were informed by previous consultation from February 2021.

View a reference copy of the February 2021 consultation paper:

Download

[Land transport of horses – Consultation paper \(PDF 178KB\)](#) [Land transport of horses – Consultation paper \(DOCX 42KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Equine industry stakeholders, livestock transporters and other interested stakeholders were invited to have a say on the costs, benefits and impacts of the proposed options outlined in the CRIS. Public consultation closed on 28 October 2022 and a total of 63 submissions were received.

View a summary of the feedback that was received on the CRIS:

- 2023

Feedback on the CRIS informed the development of a Decision Regulatory Impact Statement (DRIS) which was assessed as compliant by OIA in September 2023.

- 2024

The Queensland Department of Primary Industries (formerly the Department of Agriculture and Fisheries) and the Victorian Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action carried out consultation and worked with the National Horse Traceability Implementation Taskforce to better align record keeping requirements between the two sets of standards.

Agriculture ministers are working towards national endorsement of amendments to the land transport standards.

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